

Forgotten Music

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Music is perishable. This statement is not refuted by the amount of music that has survived for centuries and, for all we know, will continue to survive. Music which we regard as immortal is an infinitesimal part of what has been submitted by composers in the last 500 years. The bulk has disappeared, and the bulk will continue to disappear, in view of the erratic rarity of genius and the vast supply of inferior produce. What I propose to discuss is not the fact itself, the reasons for which are obvious, but the enigmatic mechanism whereby music, that has once been famous and appreciated, may disappear, temporarily or completely, and music which has for one reason or another remained unrecognised may be revived.

At a time when publication was rare, musicians had a realistic attitude to the problem: they wrote their music for an actual demand or occasion and nobody thought about its durability. It may even have contributed to the artist's integrity that he was undisturbed by ambition, that he had no other thought on his mind than to fulfil honestly a task of the moment. This was Bach's attitude and this was Haydn's when the one had to write a church cantata for the following Sunday, or the other a symphony for his princely employer's next dinner party. They did their best as honest craftsmen.

Well, contemporaries did not always recognise the great musician amongst a crowd of inferiors, and his situation was particularly problematic when his music had only the scantiest chance of becoming known. When Bach, in 1723, took charge of church music in Leipzig, Germany was still suffering from the ravages of the Thirty Years War and a musician's activity was restricted within the narrowest limits. The tiny fraction of his works that Bach was able to publish, at his own expense, hardly gave him any publicity. When he died in 1750, none but a handful of friends and disciples bothered about his music. Nevertheless, it survived at St Thomas's Cathedral, where Mozart heard a motet of his when he passed through Leipzig in 1789. Several years before he had had a chance to lay hands on a handwritten copy of the 'Forty-Eight', and the impression it made on him was decisive for the later development of his style. Thus Mozart became the first posthumous disciple of Bach. Beethoven, a pupil of Neefe, who had been a pupil of Bach's son Carl Philip Emanuel, already grew up with the 'Forty-Eight' and he studied them all his life.

I mention this in order to emphasise how problematic the chance of survival of great music still was in the eighteenth century. Handel, Bach's close contemporary, was fortunate; he lived in a wealthy country and enjoyed the patronage of a rich aristocracy. Handel's and Bach's positions in the world were as different as a palace and a hovel. This is why Bach's work offers the most spectacular example of buried treasure and its exhumation. Mendelssohn's performance of the St Matthew Passion in Berlin in 1829, a century after the first performance in Leipzig, paved the way for further progress in the recovery of Bach's music. But only in 1850, at the centenary of Bach's death, was a complete edition of his works started, the last volume of which did not appear until the end of the century. Bach's posthumous influence was enormous and there was no musician of the nineteenth century who escaped it, perhaps with the sole exception of Berlioz. For Brahms the annual volume of the Bach Complete Edition to which he had subscribed meant more than any contemporary score that ever came into his hands.

Nor was Bach the only great composer of his time who had to be discovered by posterity. Another close contemporary of his, Domenico Scarlatti, who lived at the Spanish court in Madrid, was almost equally secluded from publicity. His sonatas for harpsichord, one of the most magnificent contributions to keyboard music of all times, had to wait until our century to

become accessible in a complete edition.

Dictionaries are a good source of information on the musical opinion of a period. George Grove was a sound and well-trained musician but he nonetheless shared the prejudices of his time. It is strange that his original article on Cimarosa, written for the first edition of his dictionary of music, published in 1879, is still to be found in my copy of the Grove Dictionary, that of 1940. Domenico Cimarosa, a celebrated contemporary of Mozart, is mainly remembered for his most famous opera, *Il matrimonio segreto*. Grove writes: 'Cimarosa was the culminating point of genuine Italian opera. His invention is simple but always natural; and in spite of Italian love of melody he is never monotonous, but both in form and melody is always in keeping with the situation. In this respect *Italian opera has manifestly retrograded since his time*.'

So we are told that the decline of Italian opera, starting with Rossini, had continued with Donizetti, Bellini and Verdi—odd to read! But we remember that all through the nineteenth century, both in Germany and in this country, running down Italian opera was a favourite topic with serious judges of music, and the more audiences flocked to this frivolous pastime, the more its questionable quality had to be pointed out. Grove's most respected German colleague, Hugo Riemann, who in 1882 also published a dictionary of music, puts Verdi rather below Meyerbeer, for whom he has not much admiration either.

All the same, the fact that only a fraction of the output of those great Italian composers was maintained in the operatic repertory was hardly the result of such highbrow criticism but rather of a natural selection from an enormous supply. Here we are confronted with the phenomenon of total or temporary disfavour into which works can fall which, once upon a time, were favourites. And the occasional rediscovery of such forgotten works—we have witnessed a great many of Rossini's, Donizetti's, Bellini's and Verdi's operas revived after many years—is equally puzzling. Apart from a change of fashion which may cause a temporary or definite eclipse, and intrinsic qualities which are certainly the most decisive justification of a rediscovery, our century has developed an inexhaustible curiosity for the creative output of previous periods and centuries, and the results are sometimes questionable. The great cemetery of forgotten music, opened to the diggers, has been turned over and over at an ever increasing speed since the complete editions of the works of the great classics inaugurated a period of unlimited historical interest.

It is a tricky specialist's job to arrive at an authentic, reliable text from sometimes contradictory manuscript sources, and it may happen that the enthusiasm of a discovery may prevail over a critical appreciation of the object's artistic value. I have before me the score of an opera by Gluck, *L'Innocenza giustificata*, published in the Austrian Denkmäler series many years ago, to which I had to contribute a continuo. Written a few years before Gluck's first master opera, *Orfeo*, it is an almost uninterrupted string of arias, much like so many operas by Handel but without the blessing of Handel's wide range of invention and art of writing, and it is introduced by an overture whose inane emptiness defies comparison. One may find better ones by any third rate contemporary of Gluck's, say by Galuppi or Wagenseil. There is a tremendous gap between Gluck at his best and Gluck at his worst, and however sublime he can be in his great dramatic moments, he can be unspeakably insipid when his deeper feeling is not aroused. His earlier Italian operas are hardly suitable for a complete edition.

Poor music, in point of fact, was abundant in Gluck's early time, the mid-eighteenth century, which was a period of questionable workmanship, strikingly in contrast to the preceding generation, represented by such composers as Bach and Handel, Couperin and Rameau, Scarlatti and Pergolesi. You see, there can be ample reasons for music to be forgotten, and in such cases an attempt to revive it is futile.

Owing to the ever increasing publicity in which musical events have taken place since the nineteenth century, the process of selection and elimination seems to have been much more

reliable, and it is not easy to find forgotten music of this period that has not deserved its eclipse. Contributions of any importance could not easily remain totally disregarded. It always takes a considerable time for real values to emerge, but in the end the assessment is probably just. The amazing thing is how erratic a contemporary view can be and how even the most competent judge is exposed to errors. Robert Schumann, who enthusiastically hailed the first work of Chopin's that came into his hands, who was the first to introduce Berlioz, to introduce Brahms to his readers, wrote almost as enthusiastically about Sterndale Bennett and Niels Gade and was able to put Norbert Burgmüller—some of his little pieces have survived in piano albums—beside Schubert. We learn of another forgotten master when we read a reference to Beethoven in *Musical World*, an English music magazine of the 1830s; I quote: 'In the obstinate manner in which he [Beethoven] drives one passage through and through and against another, he has no equal except Sebastian Bach and our own illustrious Samuel Wesley.'

Nothing is as difficult as an objective evaluation of an individual artist if one does not see him from the distance necessary for a proper perspective. Looking through old programmes of the Reid Concerts in Edinburgh, I found one from 1859 in which a footnote indicates one item as: 'In memory of the greatest composer of our time who died on 22nd of October.' Guess who this was: Spohr—at a time when Rossini was still alive, when Berlioz and Verdi were famous, when Brahms was already known, when Wagner was in the limelight of publicity! Having mentioned Rossini, I remember a precious passage in a preface the French poet Lamartine wrote for the memoirs of Lorenzo da Ponte when they were published in Paris in 1850. He duly informs his readers that Da Ponte was the librettist of Mozart, *ce Rossini de son siècle*—'that Rossini of his century'. So much for the perspective of a contemporary!

All the same, Louis Spohr's music, famous during his lifetime but soon forgotten and buried for nearly a century, is very much worth considering. His operas, his oratorios, his symphonies have faded and are probably beyond recovery. But much of his chamber music deserves attention, music of a master craftsman with an attractive style of his own. The danger of total loss in spite of high artistic qualities is most acute in opera, with its elusive problems of combining music and drama. Therefore the mortality rate of opera has always been enormous and mitigating circumstances, which allow a reprieve, are rare. An arguable case is Peter Cornelius's *Der Barbier von Bagdad*. It failed dismally at its first performance in Weimar in 1858 because it coincided with a noisy demonstration against Liszt who conducted it and the composer never heard it again. It occasionally returns to the stage but it has never taken its place where it really belongs, among the finest masterpieces of comic opera. Still more neglected is another work of the same species, *Der Corregidor* by Hugo Wolf, a fount of precious music, written, it is true, by a composer who had no experience of the theatre and paid the penalty for it.

Regarding contemporary judgment and its fallibility, our century is certainly no exception, and the distance necessary for an assessment has not diminished either. If one looks back over a long period of time, as I do, one will remember the oddest evaluations. When I was young, Scriabin was regarded by serious critics as the greatest of all Russian composers, greater than Tchaikovsky or Mussorgsky. In Germany between the wars Franz Schreker loomed almost larger than Richard Strauss as a representative of contemporary opera, and Respighi was one of the greatest modern composers. And still in the later thirties one could read statements such as 'Bach, Mozart and Elgar', and Sibelius was regarded by many as the greatest symphonic composer since Beethoven. I guess a great many corrections with respect to present day evaluations will have to be made in the next fifty years. And if perhaps not much will re-emerge that is being forgotten today, much will be forgotten which today is at the centre of the public view.

Considering the importance of the printed word in leading or influencing public opinion, it is no wonder that there was never a lack of efforts of the kind we call propaganda in politics.

Public opinion is a result of a democratic process and this holds for music as for art or poetry or any kind of human activity. All of us who are interested in a matter do vote pro or con and our votes are recorded without our being aware of it. This is the legitimate process of forming opinion. But there are methods of bending it in one direction or another, as politicians have discovered long ago. Gluck was probably the first great composer to realise the enormous potentialities of propaganda in promoting success and the first to organise and cultivate his press relations, providing material for his supporters, formulating his artistic aims, ridiculing his opponents and being aware of every tactical advantage to secure his position in Paris in the 1770s. His most successful follower in this line was Meyerbeer in the 1830s. Meyerbeer was fabulously rich and could afford any expense connected with such efforts. Heinrich Heine, the German poet who lived in Paris at that time, poked fun at the great composer, suggesting that he would bequeath in his last will a sizeable capital to each of his beloved operas in order to maintain them comfortably and well equipped on the stage. Well, his operas did maintain themselves in the repertory for half a century after his death in 1864, but at the time of the First World War they had already faded so much that operatic audiences had become tired of them and they are hard to resuscitate nowadays. Wagner devoted colossal efforts, in books and pamphlets, to the promotion of his ideas, fighting heroically against the abomination of traditional opera. He succeeded magnificently in establishing himself but not in destroying opera. Bernard Shaw, one of Wagner's most devoted partisans, could be disarmingly unconcerned in twisting facts in order to plead such a holy cause. This he did when, in reviewing a performance of *II Trovatore* in 1888, he tried to discredit Wagner's most successful operatic contemporary, Verdi, on his own most legitimate ground, namely as a vocal composer. He writes: 'Verdi, Gounod, Sullivan and the rest wrote so abominably for the human voice that the tenors all had the goat-bleat and were proud of it, the baritones had a shattering vibrato and could not, to save their lives, produce a note of any definite pitch and the sopranos had the tone of a locomotive whistle without its steadiness; all of this being the result of singing parts written for the extreme upper fifth of voices of exceptional range, because high notes are pretty. But today our singers, trained on Wagner, who share with Handel the glory of~being great among the greatest writers for the voices, can play with Verdi, provided they have not to do with it too often.' Had he asked any singer, he would have been told that the contrary was true.

On the opposite side Nietzsche, the most prominent philosopher of that period, who, after having been a close friend and partisan of Wagner became his most stubborn critic, put against Wagner not only Bizet's *Carmen*, a work of genius, but an obscure German composer, Peter Gast, to whom he happened to be personally attached. Well, Wagner's greatness, like Verdi's, could stand all pros and cons, and Peter Gast, like innumerable others, has long been forgotten. But public controversy on such a level is rather an obstruction to fair play in the formation of public opinion.

It remains to be seen how good or bad the present day influence of the mass media will turn out to be. We must learn to face the fact that a statement is not necessarily true because it has been printed or broadcast. Optimists may hope that there is a saturation point in swallowing the critical opinions thrown at us incessantly. And this, in the end, may even offset the spurious results achieved by controlled public opinion as it is practised under totalitarian regimes. Experience shows that enthusiastic music lovers have a mind of their own; and a secret of the ballot that goes on permanently is that their vote counts threefold because it is maintained with conviction. Now you would like me to tell you which of the composers celebrated today will be forgotten in half a century: I am no soothsayer. Make your own guess, it is as good as mine.

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